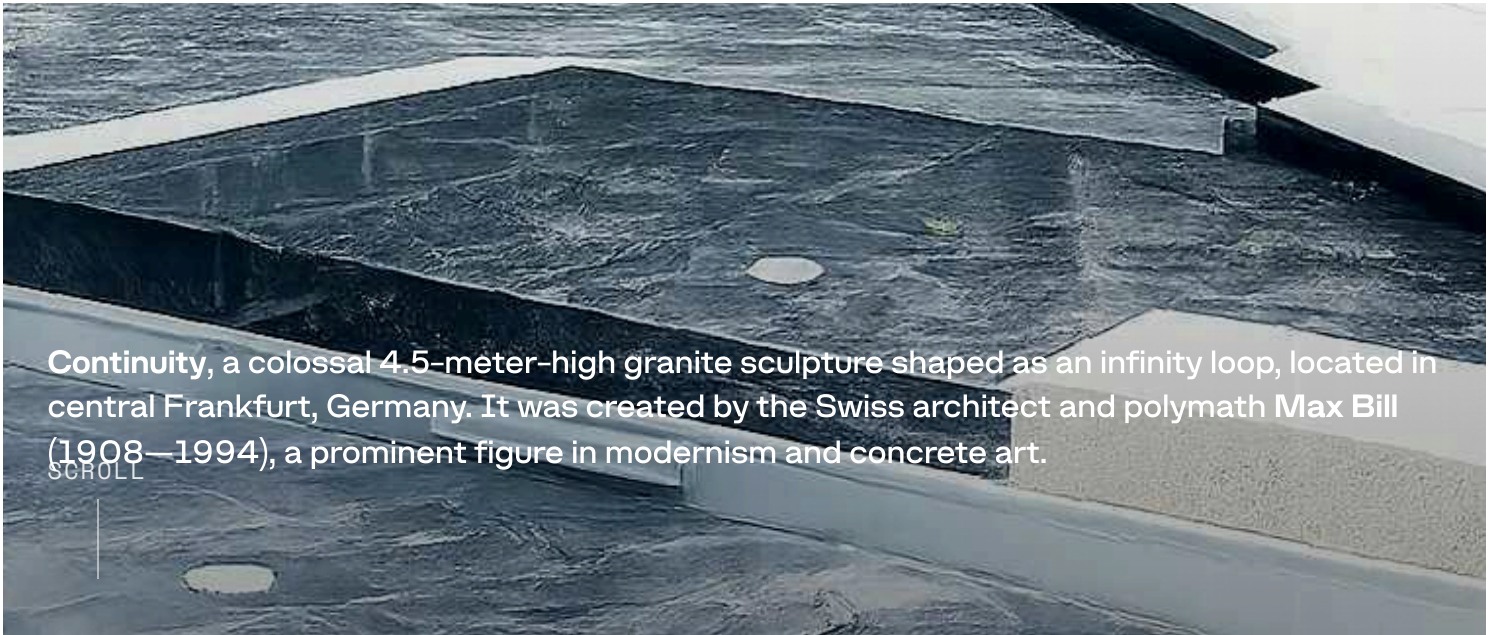




FRANKFURT • 50°07'N 8°41'E



toward kontinuität



Continuity, a colossal 4.5-meter-high granite sculpture shaped as an infinity loop, located in central Frankfurt, Germany. It was created by the Swiss architect and polymath Max Bill (1908—1994), a prominent figure in modernism and concrete art.

SCROLL

Imagine a 200-ton block of granite, extracted from a quarry in Sardinia in the 1980s, carved into a work of art and shipped across the North Atlantic, then transported through Europe via canals and rivers — before finally being installed as a monumental infinity loop in the heart of Frankfurt's financial district. Such an undertaking, combining production and logistics, had not been seen since the transport of colossal

sculptures carved from monoliths in ancient Egypt. So what was the idea behind it, and what made it possible forty years ago?

1

“In Continuity, I attempted to realize an idea that had long been present in my mind: the

representation of an infinite space in infinite motion. Subsequently, I engaged with the problems realized in it, which are extraordinarily fascinating. That sculpture consists of a band of uniform width throughout, whose edges are therefore parallel. It thus appears to be a two-sided surface, separated from the surrounding space by parallel lines and forming a new space. The phenomenon of this “body,” however, is that this new space-forming surface has only a single side, and that the seemingly parallel two lines are in fact only one single line—that is, a line running parallel to itself.”

In *Continuity*, I intended to achieve something similar: a surface, a boundary. Purely theoretically, from a twin band—one that is twisted one and a half times around itself and fused with another that is twisted only half a turn—one could obtain a form similar to the “endless loop,” but with only one surface and one boundary. For reasons unknown to me, this did not come about. Thus *Continuity*, despite a theoretically different expected result, consists of two parallel, bounded surfaces,

composed of infinitely many straight lines.

This explanation may seem somewhat dry and primitive, yet it is the only thing I can say about it myself. I can, however, add that for me such a sculpture represents something like a “knot in space,” a point of concentration of various latent directions, and that through its existence space is ordered, newly formed, and given aim and direction.

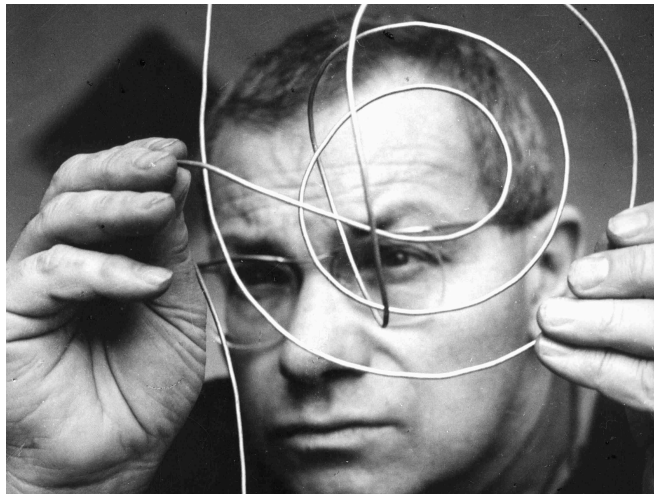
There is continuity in our purpose. However our purpose is also to see—and to see clearly. We [designers] are not working for the sake of machines, for some impersonal, superordinate entity such as ‘industry’ or ‘state’ or ‘community’. We are working for the wellbeing of every person, every individual, as part of a community. <...> This purpose, this new humanism, is what I’d like to see as continuity.

Max Bill, “Continuity and change”, 1953

Year

1986

2

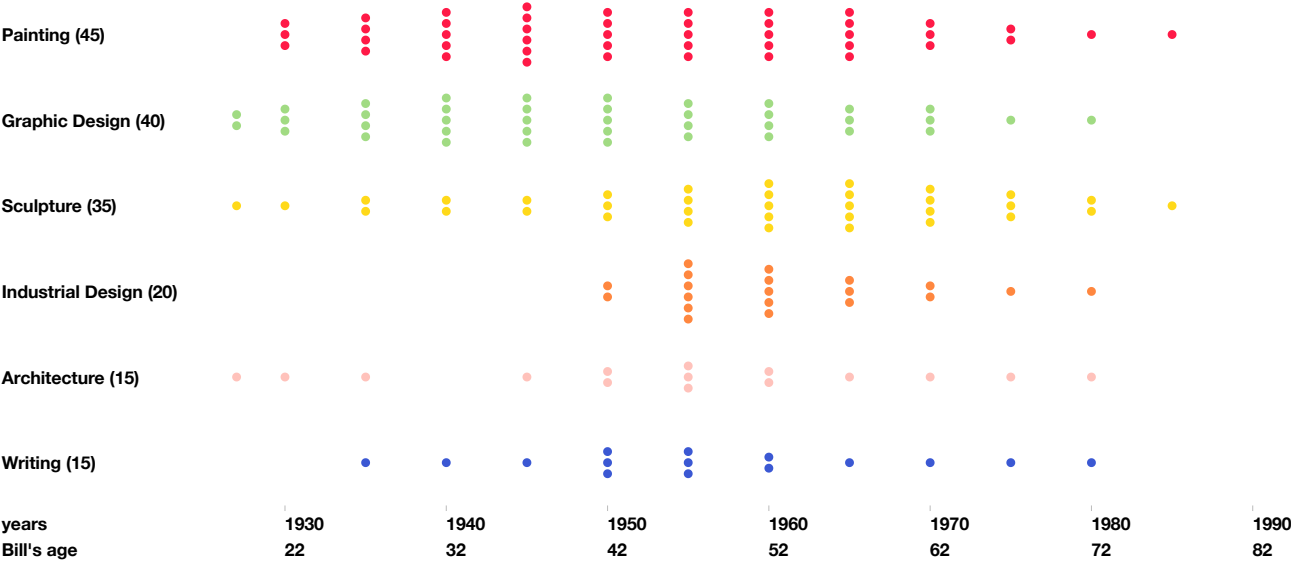


Max Bill (1908—1994) was a great Swiss polymath: architect, industrial and graphic designer,

sculptor, painter — and also a prolific writer, scholar, and teacher.

He attended the Bauhaus where he was taught by Josef Albers, László Moholy-Nagy, Paul Klee, Wassily Kandinsky and Oskar Schlemmer. Bill remained closely associated with the Bauhaus school and was a key figure in developing and propagating its principles — as a guest lecturer at the Kunstgewerbeschule Zürich, and as a co-founder and first rector of the Ulm School of Design.

Max Bill's works



Bauhaus

Ulm School

National Council

Hamburg HfbK

3

distance

2,800 km

countries

5

time

6 months

01

Granite Trip

QUARRY SCARRACIANA → PORTO DI SANTA TERESA GALLURA → PORTO MARINA DI CARRARA





The granite was found at **Cava Scarraciana**, a quarry in the sun-bleached silence of north-eastern Sardinia. On 20 October 1983, a 500-ton block was blasted from the rock face and reduced on site to 180 tons — a polyhedron ready for transport.

PLACE

Cava Scarraciana

DATE

20 · 10 · 1983

MASS

500 t → 180 t

25 · 04 · 1983

The "Esagono" work collective is formed around Dominique Stroobant in Carrara.

13 · 09 · 1983

Max Bill and Rodolfo Costantino inspect the Scarraciana quarry.

20 · 10 · 1983

A granite block is blasted and extracted — 500 tons.

OCT - NOV 1983

The block is reduced to 300 tons, then to 180 tons, formed into a polyhedron, and loaded onto a Fagioli truck with a 52-metre platform.



STOP 02 / 03



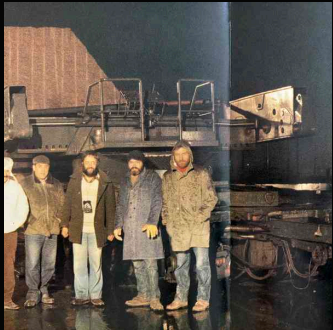
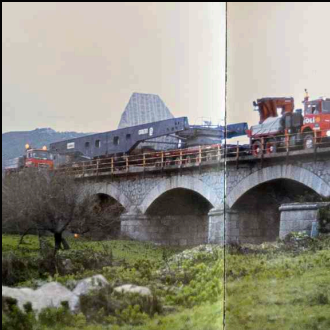
Loaded onto a Fagioli truck with a 52-metre platform, the block crossed Sardinia by night to the port of **Santa Teresa Gallura**. A temporary road

was built to reach the highway; the public route was closed for two days, 8–9 February 1984.

LEG	DATE	CONVOY
Sardinian crossing	08 — 09 · 02 · 1984	52 m platform

. . . A temporary road is built to the main highway.

08 — 09 · 02 · 1984 The road is blocked for two days while the convoy carries the block across Sardinia to the port of Santa Teresa di Gallura.



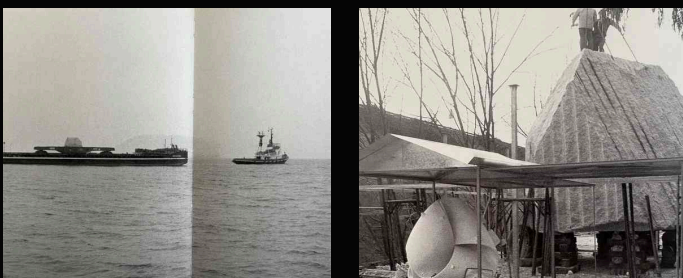


After a ten-day wait for fair weather, the cargo crossed the Tyrrhenian Sea to **Marina di Carrara**, where the workshop of the Esagono collective was waiting on the Tuscan coast.

PLACE	DATE	DISTANCE
Marina di Carrara	20 · 02 · 1984	+360 km · sea

Ten-day wait due to weather conditions.

20 · 02 · 1984	The ship arrives at the port of Marina di Carrara.
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Sculpting

WORKSHOP · MARINA DI CARRARA · FEBRUARY 1984 — JUNE 1986

A site near the port was chosen for convenient stone transport and waste handling — roughly 120 tons of granite would have to be removed. A temporary metal building rose around the block, with a separate pavilion housing the four-fold magnified plaster model that served as the master measurement.

- I Workshop built**
Work began February 1984. A site near the port was chosen for stone transport and waste handling.
- II Measurement transfer**
A grid of "measuring points" was transferred from a four-fold magnified gypsum model using giant dividers.
- III Diamond chains**
The carving used drilling machines and specially made diamond chains — regular chains are made for marble, not granite.
- IV Carving from the inside**
The sculpture was carved from the inside using complex and dangerous methods. Work was done in shifts: only two people could be inside at a time.
- V Internal channels**
Gradually, long internal channels — necessary for the loop's hidden topology — were cut out.

VI

January 1985

Main through-cuts completed. The interior shape begins to emerge.

VII

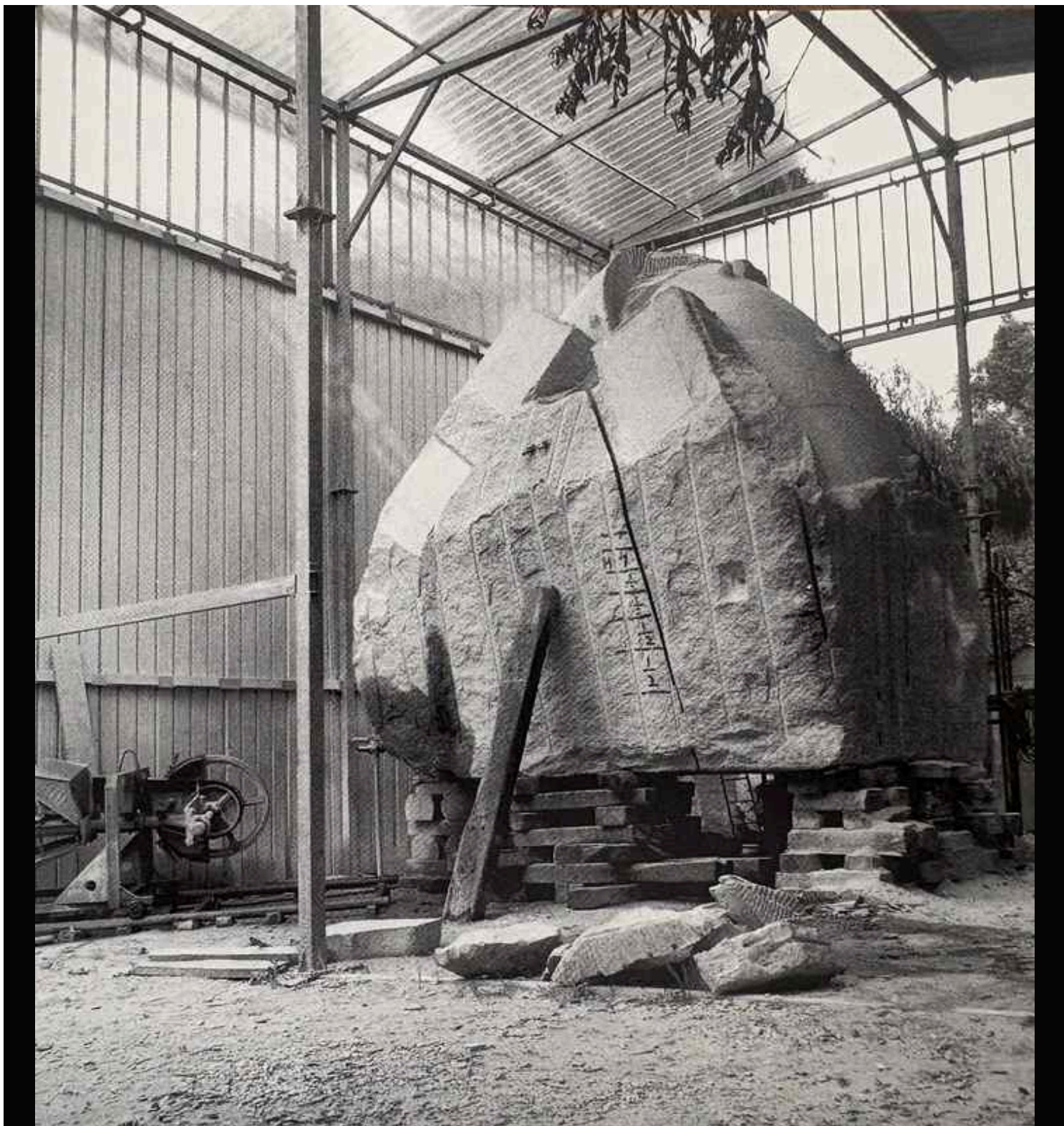
22 March 1986

The sculpture is turned over and placed on three support points; carving continues.

VIII

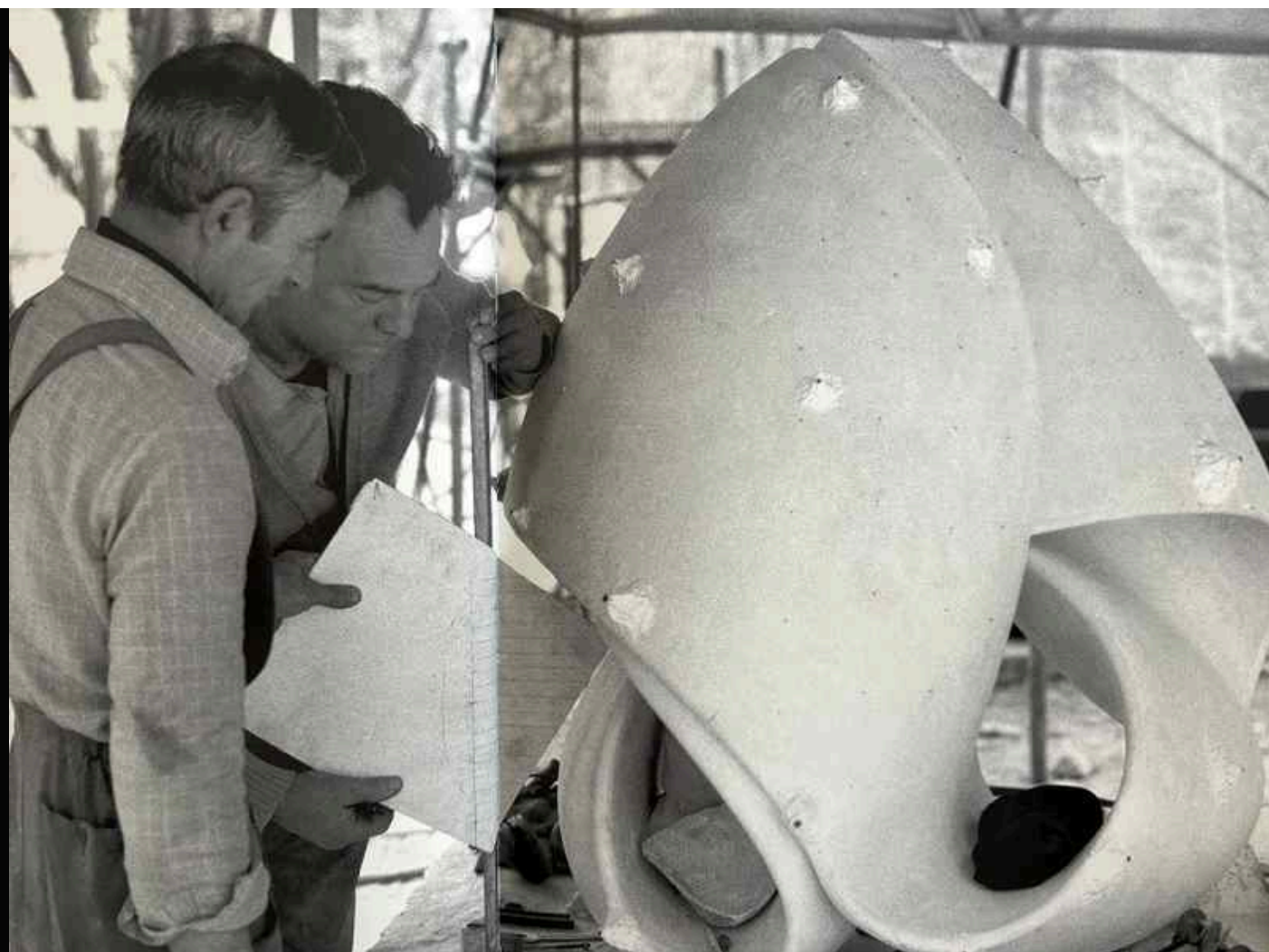
30 June 1986

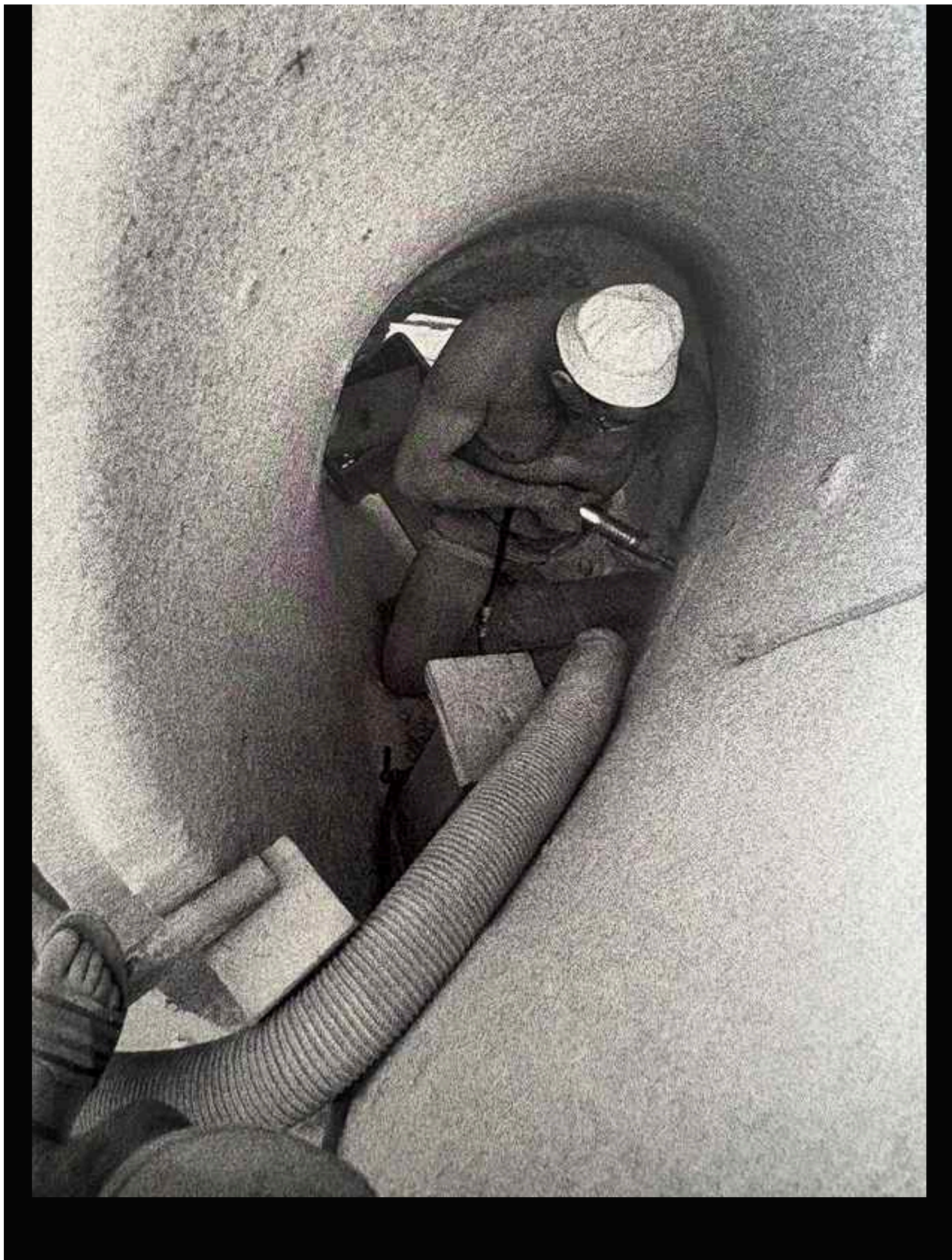
The sculpture is completed.

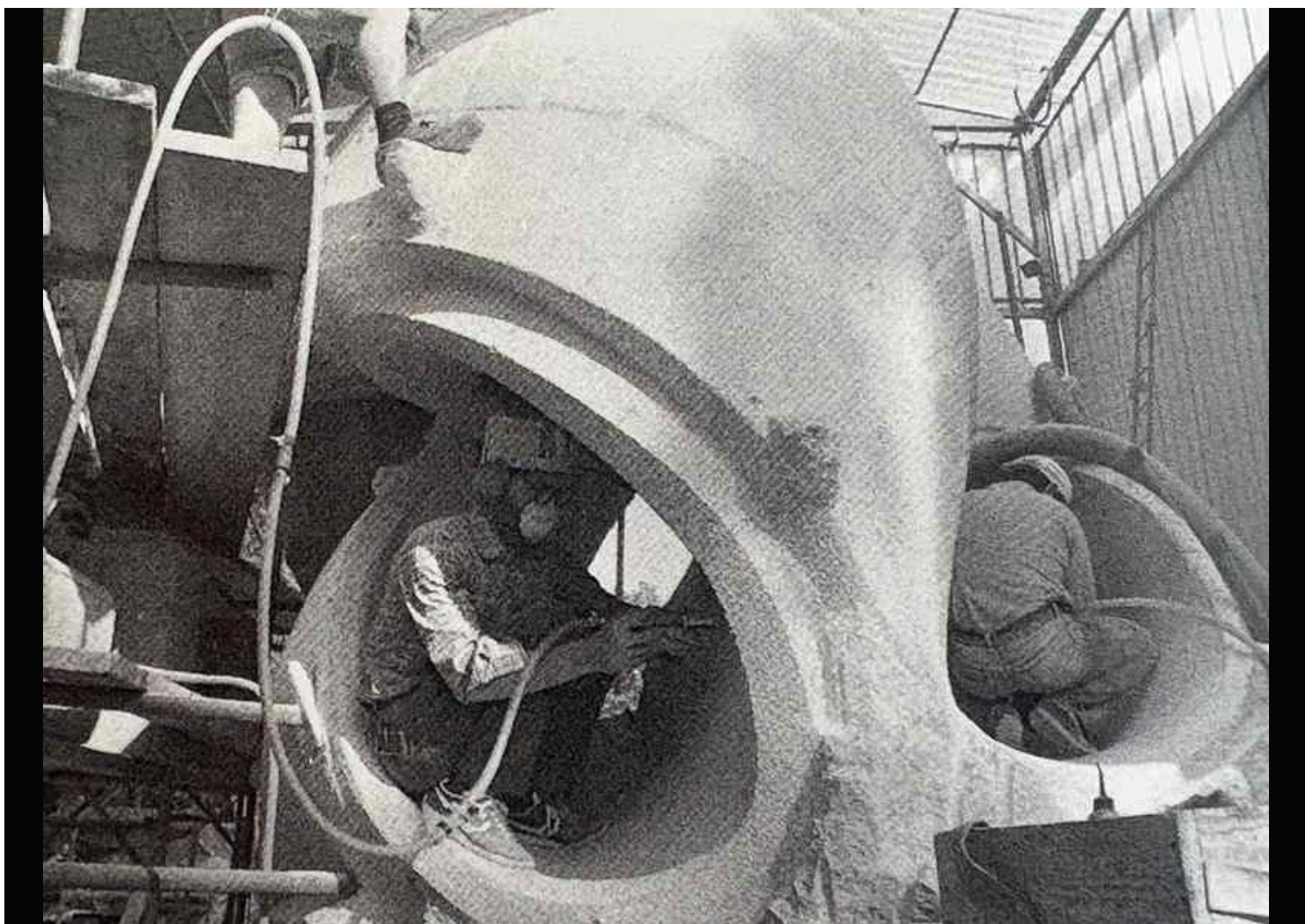


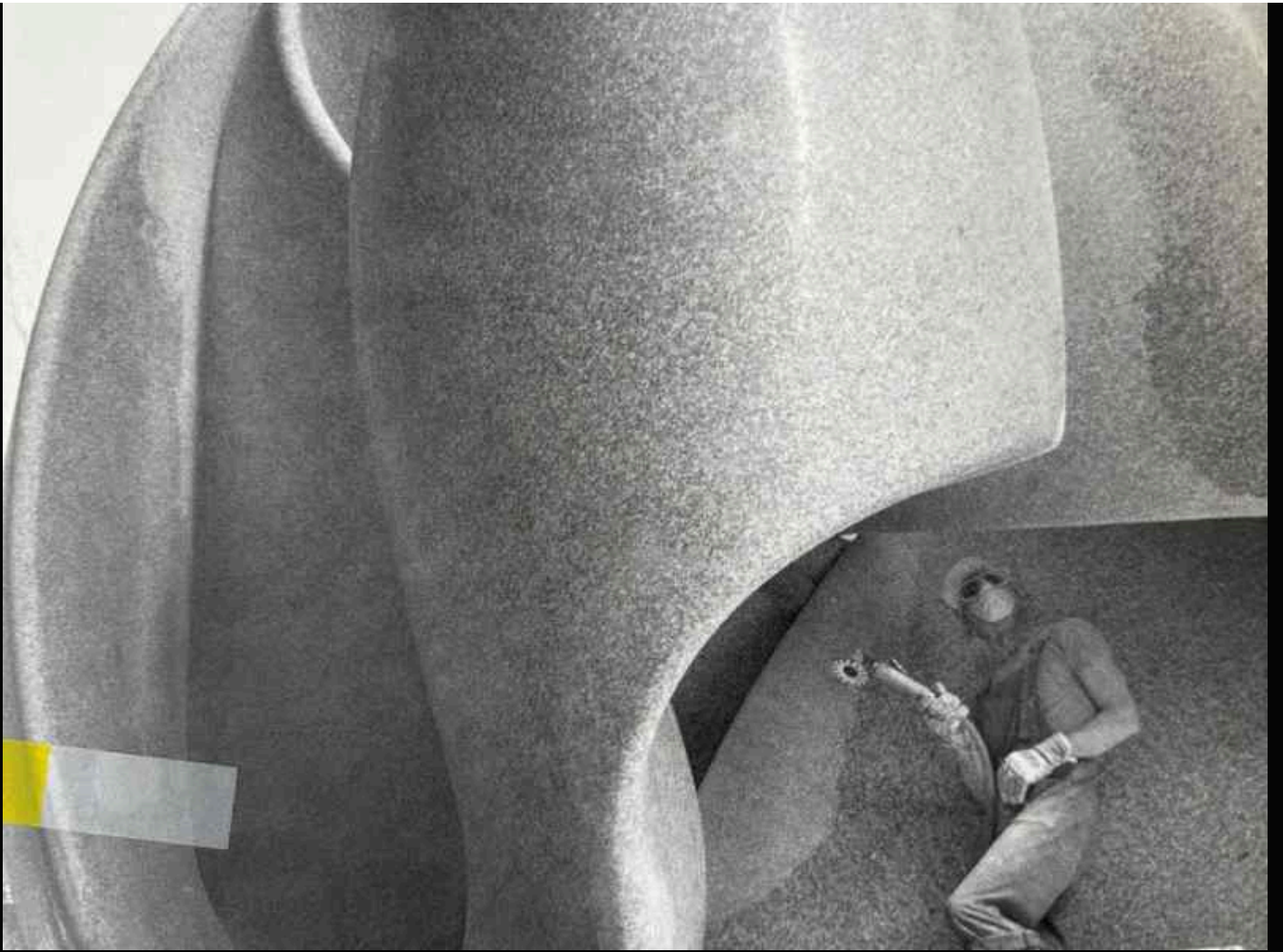


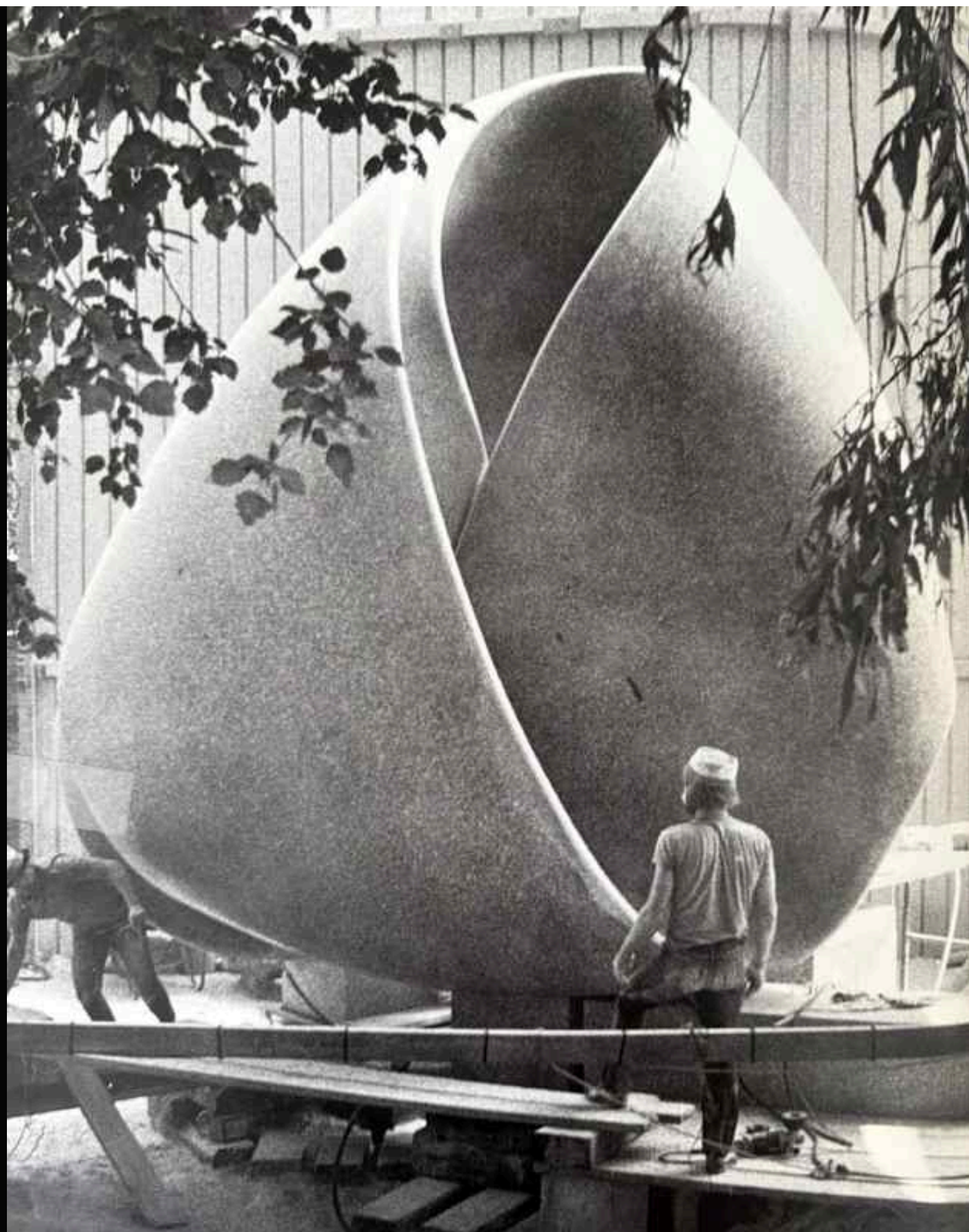












Sculpture Trip

PORT OF CARRARA → GIBRALTAR → PORTUGAL → BAY OF BISCAY → ENGLISH CHANNEL → ROTTERDAM →
RHINE · MAIN → FRANKFURT AM MAIN





Between 4 and 8 August 1986, the finished **Continuity** was mounted into a sturdy steel transport frame in Carrara and loaded onto the cargo ship **MV Kupari**.



The Kupari sailed via the **Strait of Gibraltar**, west of Portugal, across the **Bay of Biscay** and through the **English Channel** to the North Sea — a 2,800 km open-water passage taking just over two weeks.





After unloading in **Rotterdam**, the sculpture was transferred to a river barge and pushed up the **Rhine** and **Main** rivers toward the German interior.

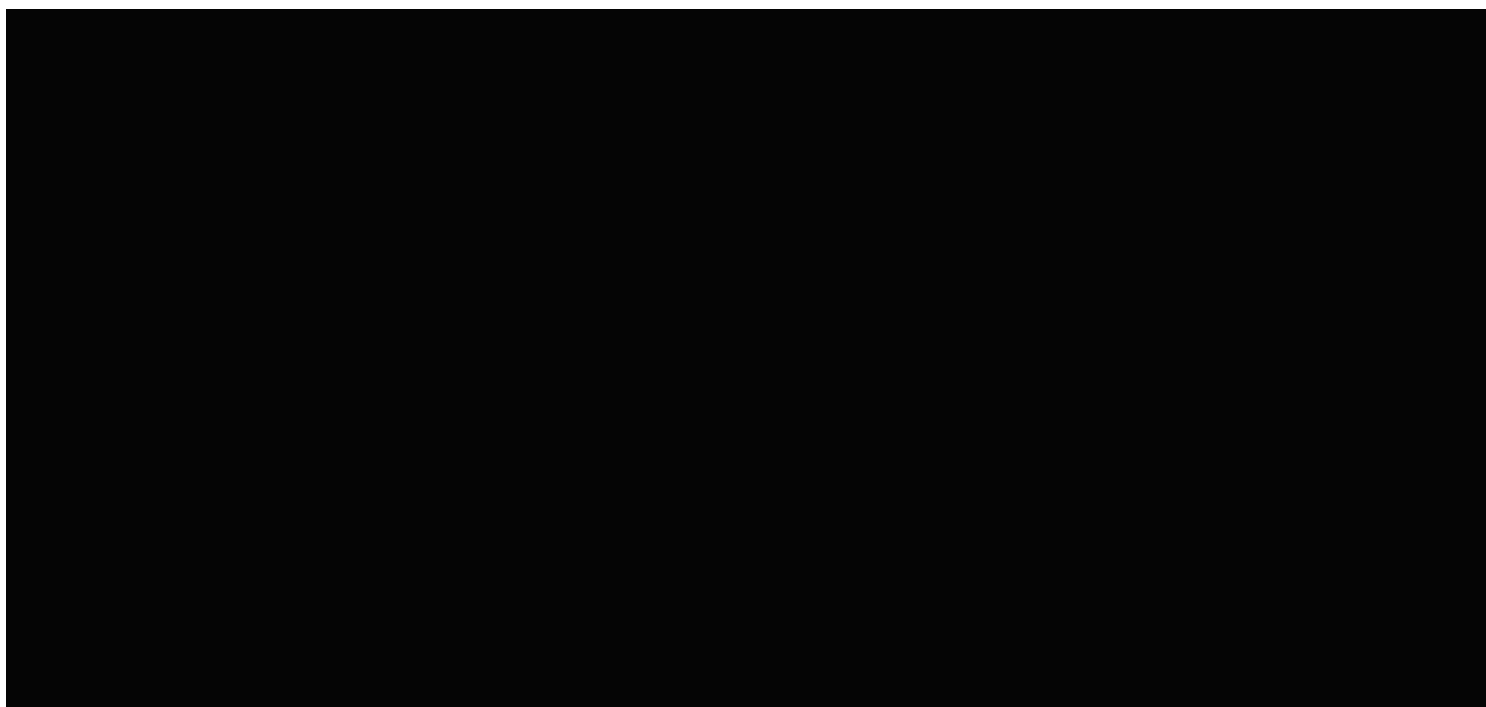


In Frankfurt, a **Colonia** crane moved from the Osthafen to Taunusanlage 12 lifted the 80-tonne sculpture above the trees and into place beside the Deutsche Bank towers the following morning.





4





In 1981, Max Bill met the young and energetic sculptor and photographer Dominique Stroobant. This encounter grew into a lifelong friendship. Their greatest challenge would become

the project Continuity — the development of which took three years.

Stroobant was responsible for the entire production process: from planning the transportation route of a massive block of granite, to the creation of the full-scale, four-meter sculpture together with his team of four sculptors.

Dominique Stroobant is a Belgian artist and mathematician known for his work at the intersection of geometry, perception and conceptual art. His practice explores spatial structures, continuity, and transformation — often translating abstract mathematical principles into precise visual or sculptural expressions.

CONTENT TBD

5



Max Bill was consistently inspired by mathematics and logic in art. His approach, which he called “verifiable logic,” guided him from early experimentation toward a precise method of making—and explaining—his work: “You can always understand my work, even if you don’t like it.” From the beginning of his career, Bill was fascinated by the Möbius strip. From his first attempts in 1936 to the realization of *Continuity* in Frankfurt, he produced dozens—if not hundreds—of variations on the infinity loop, exploring differences in scale, material, and environment.

But how are we to understand the topology of *Continuity*? Is it a Möbius strip, a variation on an endless loop, or simply an artistic, sculptural interpretation of an infinite motif? In short, how did he do it? Even though Bill left some explanations, our own experiments and consultations with mathematicians did not yield an immediate understanding of how the sculpture was conceived and modeled.